In Her Shoes

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44086659.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Body Swap, swapped bodies, Freaky Friday - Freeform, Friends to Lovers, Estranged Friends to Lovers, Miscommunication, Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Useless Lesbians, SPOP Flex Secret Solstice (She-Ra), SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), Christmas, Christmas Fluff, Hanukkah, Hanukkah Fluff, Best Friend Squad (She-Ra), Super Pal Trio (She-Ra), New Year's Eve, New Year's Kiss, New Years, Inspired by Kimi no Na wa. | Your Name., Photographer Adora, Jewellery Designer Catra, Catradora went to art school, cher, Chervoyance, Body swap invoked by Cher, Is Razz Cher?, Jewish Catra

Language:
English

Collections:
SPOP Flex Secret Solstice, Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables, Spop Magical Cher Nonsense

Stats:
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by thedeafpomegranate

Summary

A Freaky Friday / Your Name inspired holiday mash-up where an estranged yet secretly in love Catradora start waking up in each other's bodies. Festive fluff and chaos ensues!

"Wildcat! You up? We're leaving in half an hour!"

Wildcat?

She's only ever known one person who'd be likely to have a nickname like that, but she definitely cant have gone home with…

Adora shrieks as she catches sight of herself in the mirror opposite the bed, her palms flying to the mattress to steady herself. Suddenly, she can tell why the room she's in feels strangely familiar: she's spent countless hours staring at the artwork displayed on these walls before;the grumbling cat looks exactly like the one she pretends she's never seen on the Instagram profile that she's definitely never lurked on in the middle of the night;and the aged leather jacket thrown over the chair in the corner used to frequently hang on the hook by her door. She rubs at her cheeks as she rushes out of bed to the mirror, searching the heterochromatic irises that are no longer both blue, and pressing her fingertips into freckles that she's never found on her own face.

Notes

Happy New Year to SunShine / @rackedFishT ank, my SPOP Flex giftee for this Winter Solstice!This is a little fic far out of my comfort zone but one that hopefully delivers the Catradora, Super Pal Trio and Best Friend Squad fluff you love!

A huge thank you to EmileeDoodles, tshjrtile and motherofchimeras for reading this in advance and giving me the confidence to finish this story (which very nearly got away from me)!

Wishing everyone a wonderful start to 2023 and year filled with excellent fan fiction and friendship :) I hope you all enjoy reading this!Kudos and feedback in the comments would be the perfect gift xx

See the end of the work for more notes

CHAPTER 1

Adora Grey's normal morning routine is simple: up at six-fifteen, washed and dressed by six-thirty and swiftly out the door by seven. Yet it's already past nine on Friday morning when an unexpected weight digs into her shoulder and wakes her up, quickly followed by another on her spine.

"Mrrp"…

The oddly familiar chirrup echoes down her ear, but it isn't until she wriggles further into the pillows, her palm snaking up to graze cold metal at her naked breast, that her eyes actually snap open.

No, no no, I did not *get a nipple piercing while drunk…*

Panic spreads through Adora as she grasps at her chest, rolling onto her back to fix her fingers into her hair. Only, it isn't smooth strands that her fingernails sift through when she massages her scalp;when she jams them in, she's countered by firm waves with much higher density, their thick shafts pushing back against her touch.

If Glimmer thinks she can play some weird prank on me, like a goddamn nipple piercing and a p-perm, I'm gonna murder her!

Adora sits upright sharply, pulling the covers vigorously as she moves and gasping as a disgruntled tabby cat hisses angrily at her in response. She scrambles to pull more of the bedding close to her, her confusion only building as she looks around the room. It isn't hers, and she doesn't remember going home with anyone the night before. Neither though, does she remember getting a nipple piercing or agreeing to some random hair treatment that she's absolutely sure you can't get appointments for at two in the morning.

“Just think back,”she tells herself nervously , desperate to figure it all out before the girl she’s apparently hooked up with returns, “What did you do last night, and where did you go?”

Adora wracks her brain for memories of the previous night’s events, recalling the busy pub crammed with people celebrating the start of the festive season after work. She’s sure she only had a couple of cocktails - though you can never really tell how many measures go into the shakers when Seahawk’s behind the bar - and she remembers so many little details: the way that Bow and Glimmer seemed to lean a little closer into one another’s space when they thought she wasnt looking;the sugary saltiness of sweet potato fries with maple dip;and the catch of her breath when she thought she’d seen *her* across the room, an outline of honeyed skin and worn black leather obscured by a sea of office gatherings. Adora’s convinced she ended the night at the pub’s temperamental jukebox, ignoring the drumming of her heart against her ribcage as she dared herself to look back over her shoulder one more time.

Just in case she sees me, and it really is her.

Adora hadn’t been able to work out whether it would hurt more to see her, or to find out that it was someone altogether different. But the last time she’d seen Catra Gold, she’d never imagined they would fall apart so quickly. Ten years ago, they’d practically been fused at the hip;everyone had known that they were ride or die, and if you were hanging out with one of them, chances were you’d probably see the other. It made no sense to Adora, how all those years of friendship - even if they’d never blossomed into something different, that she’d hoped, stupidly , might bloom - had suddenly whittled into nothing. It had taken the best part of five years to come to terms with it but Adora accepts it now: her invitation had leaned too close to a date, Catra had bailed, and it was really Adora’s own fault that she’d driven her closest friend away instead of quashing her desire like a sensible person would.

Surely, she still thinks to herself sometimes, when she’s feeling lonely and perpetually doomed to singlehood, *We should have been*

enough to get past it?

It's an impossible question with an even more impossible answer, and as Adora reflects on how she got herself into this unknown bed, she scolds herself for getting so easily distracted by wounds that should have long since healed. There's a knock on the door - it's fast and peppy, and Adora freezes when she realises she's still got no idea where she is - but a voice pushes loud and clear through the wood instead of a person bursting into the room.

"Wildcat! You up? We're leaving in half an hour!"

Wildcat?

She's only ever known one person who'd be likely to have a nickname like that, but she definitely can't have gone home with…

Adora shrieks as she catches sight of herself in the mirror opposite the bed, her palms flying to the mattress to steady herself. Suddenly, she can tell why the room she's in feels strangely familiar: she's spent countless hours staring at the artwork displayed on these walls before;the grumbling cat looks exactly like the one she pretends she's never seen on the Instagram profile that she's definitely never lurked on in the middle of the night;and the aged leather jacket thrown over the chair in the corner used to frequently hang on the hook by her door. She rubs at her cheeks as she rushes out of bed to the mirror, searching the heterochromatic irises that are no longer both blue, and pressing her fingertips into freckles that she's never found on her own face.

"Holy shit," Adora notices the soft huskiness of her - *no, Catra's* - voice when she speaks, and she stumbles back, tripping over the woven rug and banging against the bedposts, "This can't be real, I can't be-"

"Catra? Are you okay in there, buddy?"

"F-fine!" Adora squeals, "Be out in a minute!"

There's no way Adora can let anyone know what's happening - who would believe her anyway? *No,* Adora decides, *it's best to go along with it and figure this out myself. The less interference, the better!*

She inhales deeply as she gears herself up for the day.

There has to be a logical explanation for this, she tells herself, *there's no such thing as magic!*

It's only then, when Adora clears her throat and tries to set her plan in place, that the penny finally drops.

"Oh my God!" Adora clenches her eyes shut hurriedly and flings her hands away from herself, a deep blush spreading over her skin, "Why..why is she sleeping topless, anyway?"

She fumbles for the discarded clothes under Catra's leather jacket on the chair, peeking through half-closed eyes to dig out underwear from the dresser. She can hardly find any boyshorts or the kind of underwear she likes herself - there's just tiny scraps of scratchy lace that Adora knows Catra never would have bought in their art college days, and it's only her desperation to respect Catra's privacy that makes her suck it up and shimmy them over her hips without hesitation, racing to pull on grey skinny jeans and a racerback bralette as quickly as she can with her eyes closed. Adora hears a voice calling for her - *well, for Catra* - and she scrapes her hair back as neatly as she can into a high pony, smoothing her scalp down with her fingers in lieu of a brush and securing it with an old scrunchie she finds jammed into the back of a makeup box.

This'll do, Adora repeats the words in the mirror like a mantra, *you can do this. Everything will be back to normal in no time!* By the time she's sitting at the kitchen table opposite two women she doesnt recognise, she almost starts to believe it.

"Erm, Wildcat? Are you sure you're alright?" The burlier , short-haired woman stares at her like she's gone crazy after she crams a rasher of crispy bacon in her mouth, "You don't normally eat that."

"I don't?" Adora's pretty sure Catra loves the stuff - she always smiles despite herself when she remembers the first time Catra tried it in student halls after a lifetime of keeping kosher in her parents' house, "Since when?"

"The thirty-first of December 2018," the other girl says, the one with the purple hair and three tech devices next to her plate of mini bread rolls and individually-wrapped pats of butter, "Lonnie bet you couldn't hack Veganuary and you told her, quote unquote, to 'go fuck yourself, meathead.'"

"It wasn't quite that dramatic," the taller woman chuckles nervously when Adora winces, "But are you sure going to work is a good idea? You seem kinda"…

"I'm great!" Adora forces a wide smile, determined not to invite more questions, "Honestly , last night was kind of a big one but I'm totally fine. Nothing to worry about, honest!"

The other two nod (though one is clearly unconvinced) and they sit through the rest of breakfast quietly. When the three of them pile into the car, it's a relief that they all seem to work in the same place as well as live together, though Adora's itching to work out what they actually do. When Adora knew her, Catra wanted to be a tattoo artist or a glassblower, or something equally creative with impossibly high stakes, and there's no way Adora could possibly get her head around doing either. When they pull up outside a boutique jewellers in central Bright Moon, Adora feels like she could faint with relief.

"What are you doing?" Catra's taller roommate asks Adora when she follows her past the shop counter into the back of the store, "You know boss wants you out front until January."

"Oh, yeah!" Adora curses herself internally , "Obviously! Just… grabbing water!"

Adora cringes for the first hour she sets up at the workstation right in the shop front window, her hands shaking as she stares at the

gleaming metal and foreign tools before her.

What the hell am I supposed to do with this?

She smiles awkwardly every time someone comes window shopping, hoping that shell wake up from this nightmare before anyone notices how useless she is. There's not too much time to dwell on it though - it's barely eleven when she sees a muscular woman charging towards the shop in the distance, long blonde hair fanned out behind her. Adora hardly has time to twist in her seat before a loud bang announces to everyone that someone's burst into the shop urgently.

"What the hell have you done, Adora? Is this some kind of sick joke?"

She's face to face with herself, and seeing it from the outside sends Adora into an even bigger mindfuck. The only saving grace is that now Adora knows it's not only her grappling with these impossible events. Her blue eyes are blazing with fury as they stare her down, and the other woman's wrath only seems to worsen when she catches sight of the botched jewellery work in front of Adora.

"Jesus, this is horrendous - youll have me sacked by lunch!"

"Catra," Adora half gasps and half wheezes out, "You...it's not just me? You're in my?..."

"Shit," she hisses back, and Adora cant quite get her head around Catra's frustration seeping out through her own features, "You dont know what's going on either?"

"Catra, maybe we-"

"Fantastic!" Catra's less self conscious than Adora remembers and her voice gets louder and louder regardless of anything Adora tries to say, "Just my fucking luck."

If this is Catra's punishment for doing tequila shots on a weeknight, it's enough to stop her from ever drinking again at all.

She stares at herself in the selfie camera of Adora's phone for the umpteenth time that morning, tapping her foot on the floor of the Uber she's riding in. Until last night, Catra was pretty sure that she was completely, totally, one hundred percent over Adora Grey. And then she just had to turn up at Catra' s local with gold tinsel braided through her hair, wearing the tightest white tank top known to humanity - *does she not know it's winter?* - and looking like she's been perfectly happy without Catra in her life at all. She replays the evening over and over, instinctively cringing as she remembers how her leather jacket had suddenly felt a little too warm, and how she'd had to use the jukebox as an excuse to get everyone of f her back for a hot second, flicking aimlessly through albums while she fought the tears threatening to spill down her cheeks.

It's embarrassing, really, that she let a meaningless glimpse of Adora affect her so much. She'd gotten so good at pretending she'd never been that shivering twenty-two year old waiting in the cold, utterly clueless as to why her best friend - *though that never felt like it summed us up properly* - stood her up for nothing. Yet the first tequila shot hadn't been enough to make her feel better , nor the second or third, or that tiny square of paper she slipped under her tongue, and now…

Now she'd woken in some outlandish pastel palace, her skin sticky with sweat against worn, greying pyjamas. It had only taken Catra seconds to curl into her pillow and recognise Adora's scent;she'd sobered up immediately when she realised how much bigger the king bed was than her small double and when she saw unforgivably pink night clothes strewn on the other side of the mattress. Her suspicions from the past had apparently turned out to be true: Adora

had chosen Glimmer Moon over her and now they were living it up in a swanky apartment she would never be able to rent. Yet when Catra had finally caught sight of herself in the mirror, cursing that, *of course,* she'd get stuck in a prolonged acid trip on a workday , five years of buried anger blazed anew.

Adora's phone buzzes in her hand and it's Glimmer's call ID showing up on the screen. Catra wants to hurl it out the window but it's too cold to let in the frost. Besides, the Uber driver clearly already thinks she's unhinged enough. She mutters irritably, her thumb hovering over the screen before she finally accepts the call.

"What, Sparkles?"

Glimmer coughs in surprise at her bluntness. *Fuck* . Not that Catra cares, but it probably isn't going to help anything if she screws over Adora's thing with the purple PowerPuff.

"Umm.. I figured you needed to sleep in after last night but do you know when you're coming into the studio today? It' s getting kinda busy."

Catra has no clue if Adora's job has changed since they last spoke, or if her studio is in the same location. She checks Adora's emails for a work inbox or any kind of indication of where her paycheck comes from, but there's nothing. All Catra knows is that the sodding lovebirds must still work together too, and that doesn't make her feel better at all. It's easier to change tack.

"I'm too sick, Ill see you later ."

"Are you in traf fic?" Catra rolls her eyes when Glimmer ignores her response, "Cos I can hear something in the background."

"It' s just the TV ."

"Y ou hate watching TV."

“ *She doesn’t* ” Catra rushes to correct herself, “I dont hate TV .”

“Okay , let’s just pretend Catragate never happened,” - *what the hell?* - “and you started snuggling feverishly on the sofa in front of Formula 1. Do you really want me to tell Mum you’re sick?”

“Y es,” Catra croaks through gritted teeth, hoping her lie isnt going to end in a visit from Angella Moon, “Please.”

“Alright, I got you,” she hears Glimmer sigh softly , an unexpected concern in her voice, “Dont start thinking I buy this, though - you cant have drunk enough for a hangover! I wanna hear the real story later.”

“Fine,” Catra’ s resigned, but if she’s lucky, she wont have to deal with the fallout if she manages to get back to her normal self, “Thanks, I guess.”

She hangs up before Glimmer can respond, keen to avoid raising any more flags. She sits in silence for the rest of the journey , blowing flyaway strands of blonde hair out of her eyes. With every second, Catra gets more and more distraught about being thrown back into Adora’s orbit, her own resilience tested and broken apart. It outrages her, that everything she’s made of herself seemingly boils into nothing at a flash of gold and white, and worse, she’s literally stuck in the middle of it.

Nothing feels sweeter than unleashing her anger when she slams the door of the Uber behind her, charging down the street to Crimson Jewels. Just as she hopes, she sees herself in the front window, staring down at the metalwork on the demonstration desk. Her brow’s furrowed, tongue sticking out - and there’s no doubt in Catra’s mind that this is Adora, and she’s ready to give her hell for it.

She feels powerful for the first time in years when she storms into the shop and confronts her, but it dissipates in minutes. Not only does the other woman seem equally as alarmed as Catra feels, but

Scorpia comes leaping to Adora's defence in a maddening twist of fate.

"Hey! If you haven't got anything nice to say, you should leave," her friend is fiercely protective, and at least Catra can appreciate her loyalty, even if it is currently misplaced, "If you need a refund or have a complaint about something, we can help you at the tills, but you can't barge in and start shouting at our jeweller!"

"Yeah, well, your *senior,* by the way, jeweller has some shit to figure out, Scorpia, so-"

"Is that a threat?" Scorpia gasps and draws her shoulders back as menacingly as she can, "And how do you know my name? Have you been stalking us?!"

Catra groans audibly. She's walked right into this like a prime idiot.

"No, no, no," Adora finally jumps in, but Catra isn't sure if it'll help or hinder her cause when she looks at Catra wide-eyed and speaks with uncertainty, "Scorpia. She's just an old friend. Adora. It's nothing to worry about, promise."

Oh, shit, Catra thinks, *there's no way this can end well.*

"Adora?" Scorpia mulls the name over before her eyes narrow and her expression hardens, "I know all about you! You hurt Wildcat more than-"

"Alright, we don't need to-" Catra tries to interject and save herself from humiliation, though of course, it doesn't work. Scorpia only continues more forcefully.

"ANYONE else ever had, and she was miserable for MONTHS after you cruelly DUMPED her-"

"I-I didn't *dump* her, Scorp," Catra's doing mental somersaults keeping up with her bestie thinking she's Adora and trying to save

face at the same time, "We've- You guys have been through this-"

"Umm, we were just friends," Adora pipes up nervously, "And I… *she didn't.that's not what happened!*"

"Bullshit." Catra speaks definitively, ignoring the pang in her chest at Adora's words, and it shuts both of them up. She hates this more than anything. All her cards are falling out on the table without her permission and she can't stand to be here for another minute of it. "I pulled a sickie," Catra leans into Adora's space hastily and says it quietly enough for Scorpia not to properly hear, "Call it in and meet me at yours."

"Catra, I can't-"

"You can," - *God, this girl and her bloody work ethic -* "You're not doing me any favours here anyway. Just do it."

When Catra hears Scorpia rush to console Adora before the door swings shut behind her, she feels even more alone than before. Yet she hardly gets to the street corner before she hears her name being called behind her and a hand clasps to her shoulder.

"Catra, wait!"

Catra jolts at Adora's touch, spinning around just in time to see the soreness of rejection wash over her face. She wonders if this is how she looked every time Adora told her she was going to hang out with her new friends from photography class instead of killing time together;it makes Catra want to ask if she was always as incapable of hiding her feelings as she used to think. Of course, she doesn't.

"You wrapped up fast," she says instead carefully, her voice measured.

"Yeah," Adora's uncomfortable, wiping her palms on the distressed jeans Catra remembers wearing the night before, "We gotta figure this out."

Catra studies Adora as she shivers in the early December wind, watching the edges of her exposed ears turning pink. She's not sure when the embers of anger smouldering inside her started to falter but Catra's clear on one thing. It's practicality rather than emotion that's going to sort this fuckery out.

"Well, then. What's the plan?"

It's odd, walking alongside Catra for the first time in years, and Adora isn't quite sure what to do with herself. It doesn't help that she keeps stumbling into the other woman, tripping over pavement cracks and upturned cobbles that she'd clear easily with her own longer strides.

"It'll be the next right," she supplies when they get closer to The Whispering Woods pub, "We're nearly there."

"It's my local," Catra replies defensively, "I know where it is. What were you even doing there last night, anyway?"

"It is?" Adora cocks her head as they turn into the right street, "I'm there kinda often and I've never seen you."

I'd remember seeing you if I did, is what she doesn't say, *I wouldn't be able to stop thinking about you.*

Catra's quiet and Adora wonders if that still means the same thing that it used to - that Catra's a little too upset or caught inside her head to respond. She decides against digging further and zips her lips until they reach the pub at the corner of the road, its green exterior wall tiles gleaming in the winter sun. It looks impossibly changed in the cool daylight, almost like it's an entirely different place. Inside, the scent of freshly baked fruit pies has replaced the usual smell of spilled beer and wine; unusually, the pub's totally

deserted besides one lone woman at the bar, her finger circling the edge of an empty glass.

"Now what?" Adora muses to herself, mumbling aloud.

"You havent got a game plan, have you?" Catra sighs, pushing past her resentfully and perching on the edge of the table in the centre of the room, "Classic."

"Classic?" Adora balks, "What's classic about being stuck in someone else's body?"

Catra raises an eyebrow, "You never used to think anything through, Adora. You just..." she sighs, never finishing her sentence.

"What?"

"You...I mean, you really thought we could just turn up here and we'd magically swap back once we crossed the threshold?" Catra looks at her sorely before she shakes her head, "Never mind. Let's just see if there's anyone who can help."

"You want Razz. This sounds right up her street," the woman at the bar's apparently been listening and she's turned around to face them. She rolls her eyes fondly as if this other person fucks shit up all the time and it's somehow endearing, "She's around, maybe."

"Maybe?" Adora presses, approaching her at the bar, "Like, is she here, or?..."

"Sometimes she's here, sometimes other times."

"What does that even mean?" Catra's clearly at the end of her tether, tapping her fingers on the wooden bar top with annoyance, "Is she here or not?"

Adora frowns. She peers at the name necklace the woman's wearing and hopes she can try and get a little more info out of her if she's nice enough.

“Look, Mara, is it? It seems like we really need to talk to Razz. Can you help us find her?”

“Adora, dearie!” A voice booms out of nowhere and Adora’s nearly bowled over by a tiny elderly woman bashing into her with a broom, “And Catra, finally - I’ve been waiting all century for you both to turn up at the same time! You’ve let my pie go stone cold.”

Adora snaps her head towards Catra and she’s just as surprised as Adora is. This woman seems to know who both of them are and addresses them correctly even in the wrong bodies.

“Razz?” Adora ventures, and Mara nods encouragingly.

“Who else?” The old woman roars at her through bottle-thick glasses and a frenzied mane of hair, “You could at least have had the manners to come with the right souls this time. Are you trying to confuse me with this swapping business?”

“Wait,” Catra interrupts Adora before she has a chance to say anything, “How can you even tell?”

Razz laughs, “It’s obvious, dearie! You were both at the jukebox in another time, after all.”

“The jukebox?” Catra and Adora echo Razz’s words at the same time, and it’s all Adora can do not to yell “Jinx!” after for old times’ sake.

“Of course, the jukebox! Aren’t you listening?” Razz pushes Adora out of the way with the tip of her broom and bustles behind the bar, disappearing into the kitchen.

“Guess you better check out the jukebox,” Mara smiles and follows Razz out of their sight, leaving them alone in the echoey pub, “Good luck!”

They gape after her, shocked into silence for a short moment.

"Does she even work here?" Adora wonders aloud, "Is she allowed back there?"

"Who gives a shit?" Catra walks away and braces her hands on either side of the old jukebox, "What did you play last night?"

"Oh," Adora stutters, "Does that really matter?"

"I don't know, it might." Catra's looking at her impatiently, "What's the problem? I already know you have terrible taste, if that's what you're worried about."

"No," Adora tries to laugh it off but it sinks hollow in her gut, "It's just a little personal, that's all."

"Personal? You played it in a packed pub last night." Catra smirks and it's the first time Adora thinks she really looks like herself since they swapped, "Besides, I've seen all your junk now, I don't think a song is much to worry about."

Catra looks over at Adora's flushed skin and snickers, "What? Don't just stand there like a goldfish, spit it out!"

"Goldfish don't stand," Adora mutters.

"Fine, I'll do mine first then," Adora waits for Catra to key in her choice, "But don't start whining about how the tune doesn't go with the lyrics. You always used to wind me up saying that."

Adora's heart begins to beat a little faster.

No matter how hard I try, you keep pushing me aside. And I can't break through. There's no talking to you…

Adora realises that she'll have to confess that she picked the very same song the night before, the one that Catra always used to sing in the shower and under her breath after a drink, and that she used to threaten the DJ to play when they went out.

It's so sad that you're leaving. It takes time to believe it. But after all is said and done, you're gonna be the lonely one, oh.

Her pulse thuds when she realises there's no choice but to explain it, to tell Catra why she wanted to play that song so much.

Do you believe in life after love? I can feel something inside me say, I really don't think you're strong enough, no!

"Are you okay?"

All she wants to do is cry.

"Hey , what's up?" Catra' s voice has gotten gentler and it reminds Adora painfully of how affectionate she used to be, "You're making me look soft, dummy."

"There' s no-one here to see," Adora snif fles.

"I'm here."

Adora looks up at Catra. There's unexpected sympathy in her blue eyes and it feels foreign after all these years.

What am I supposed to do? Sit around and wait for you? Well, I can't do that. And there's no turning back.

"I picked the same song," she finally tells her , "I thought I saw you and I wanted to pretend I still knew you for a minute."

Catra pauses, an incomprehensible expression on her face, before her facade snaps back.

"It' s three minutes and fifty-nine seconds long actually."

"Shut up," Adora scof fs, "You're doing that deflecty thing."

They both know what Adora really means: *I still know you, better than you want me to.*

"Y eah. Maybe."

I need time to move on. I need a love to feel strong.

They listen to the song together for the first time in half a decade. Adora wishes it didnt make her feel so nostalgic;she' s told herself over and over again that it's easier to miss Catra than it is to remember how much shed been hurt by her sudden withdrawal from their friendship. Now they were in front of each other again, Adora wishes she had the confidence to ask why Catra quit on her all those years ago.

'Cause I've had time to think it through. And maybe I'm too good for you, oh.

"s something meant to happen, do you think?"Adora asks, "I dont feel any different."

"Me neither ,"Catra' s disappointed and Adora somehow feels like it's her fault, "Maybe wee just stuck like this."

"Catr-"

"W e should make a real plan,"Catra' s in strategy mode now and Adora knows from experience that there's no point getting in the way, even if she really feels like they should just talk about what happened between them and hash it all out, "Fill me in on everything and then I can try not to, like, ruin your life while wee figuring this out."

"Okay ,"Adora says instead, pushing her gut instincts aside, "But who knows if weve already fixed this? W e just have to hope for the best."

CHAPTER 4

The second time Adora wakes up in Catra's body, confusion hits her instead of panic. She grabs Catra's phone and finds a message straight away.

[00] CALL: Fuck. Again?

Adora groans, falling back into her pillows. She'd really thought the jukebox had done it after waking up on December 2nd in the correct body, and God knows she's sent enough triumphant memes to Catra about being right. Except, it turns out, she isn't.

CATRA [00] Back to the pub? Maybe Mara and Razz can help us again.

[00] CALL: No point, didn't work before. Where else?

It comes to Adora slowly, and her chest drums a little louder when she finally sends her response.

CATRA [00] How about Plumeria?

Adora watches three dots appear and disappear over and over again on the screen, her fingers itching in nervous anticipation. Adora doesn't know if Catra' s ever stepped foot in a Plumeria Coffee branch since everything went wrong between them;she' s never been able to go back there herself. It isn't for another painstaking few minutes that Catra replies.

[00] CALL: Coffee's better at The Waste. Meet me in an hour.

Adora sighs. She's not surprised Catra's fobbed off her suggestion but it disappoints her more than she expects. The only positive is that she's too distracted to worry about hopping in the shower and finding clean clothes to wear this time - and Catra's certainly made it clear that she'd rather Adora wash than for everyone to think she stinks. Still, when Adora enters the zero waste eco coffee shop with Catra's reusable flask and unwraps herself from the homely knitted scarves and mittens (which she guesses Scorpia made from her

delighted look when Adora put them on), she sinks into the memory of that day in Plumeria Coffee.

She can feel every minute of the five hours she'd sat at a corner table waiting for Catra to turn up, her knee jggling against the table leg as she imagined their friendship teetering on the edge of platonic affection. Yet Adora's hope that Catra properly understood the romantic nuances of her coffee invite had morphed slowly from excitement to uncertainty before it descended into devastation. When the pitying barista finally convinced her to go home, she'd exiled her phone to the back of a drawer, curling under her duvet away from everyone.

The problem is that when Adora sees Catra arrive at The Waste, shaking snowflakes off her shoulders and out of her hair, she almost fantasises they're on the date that never happened. She' s incapable of focusing on anything Catra says.

"What' s up with you?"Catra seems both nervous and of f-put by Adora's skittishness, her head cocking to the side unsurely, "Y ou don't like it here?"

"No, no, it' s fine,"Adora responds hurriedly before she pauses, gearing herself up for the million dollar question, "I just.I've never figured out what I did to deserve it?"

"Huh?"

Catra's expression is clouded and it pushes Adora to finish her train of thought.

"Y ou ghosted me, Catra. Out of nowhere. After all those years of us being so close!"

"Are you serious?"Catra' s eyes harden and she stands from her stool opposite Adora at the high top table.

"Y ou didn't give me any leeway , you just-"

"Fuck this," Catra interrupts Adora before she can finish, "If you're trying to blame *me* for what happened, then this really is a joke."

There's nothing Adora can do when Catra storms out of The Waste except for clamp her hands around her hot chocolate, willing the warmth to counteract the coldness that's fast bleeding into her chest.

CHAPTER 8

Catra had ignored the half-joking told you so' GIFs Adora texted her when they first woke in their own bedrooms again, but she figures she's having the last laugh now. Kind of.

She groans as Adora's alarm clock goes off after snoozing it for the fifth time. She doesnt need to run her fingers through silky smooth hair or sense the weight of Glimmer on the other side of the bed to know they've swapped for a third time within a week;the ache in her bones from rousing unreasonably early tells her everything she needs to know.

Why are you like this ? Catra types on Adora's phone to her own number, *I hate you.*

She knows it's a lie and she wishes it felt better to see the words typed out. Yet Catra's thumb hovers over the screen and deletes everything, just like every other message she' s tried to send Adora over the past few days. Seeing the litany of unanswered messages from Adora's side of the conversation manages to make her feel even worse about it, but Catra's too scared to believe that any good could come from reconnecting - especially given their shitshow of a meeting at The Waste. It's infuriating, knowing that Adora really thinks their fallout is Catra's fault.

Now and again, Catra wonders if it would be worth answering one of Adora's calls and hearing it from her perspective. But she doesn't really want to learn of all the reasons why Adora decided a life without her was better than one with her. Plus, she's determined to believe that there's no greater meaning behind these body swaps or a purpose for why the universe keeps forcing them back unwillingly into each other's lives.

Now they've swapped for a third time, though. Catra can't be so sure.

She's done such a good job of swatting away the memories of Adora curling around her when they watched TV late into the night after classes, and during movie marathon sleepovers that she missed as soon as morning came. And Catra hates remembering how Adora used to make her feel like she belonged, and how the hairs on her forearms stood stiff when their shoulders brushed or they hugged a little longer than usual saying goodbye…

She'd been stupid all those years ago to read so much into things - and Catra resolves that she isn't going to give Adora a chance to get under her skin again.

Catra hauls herself out of bed and stares at Adora's face in the bathroom mirror. It's a face that's meant so many things to her, always stark in black and white but never nuanced grey. The extremes of loving and hating Adora have wrung Catra raw and she can't bear it any longer.

She ignores every message Adora sends her that day and dodges any interaction from Glimmer, holing up under the covers with an old sketchpad she digs out of the bedside drawer and calling in sick again. She knows she shouldn't, and that Adora's probably doing her utmost to keep everything ticking for her. Catra doesn't question how conscious Adora will be of maintaining her life exactly how it is, but it only makes her want to retreat more.

And just like that, she wakes up in her own body the next day.

CHAPTER 3

Adora's given up on trying to get Catra to talk to her. It's been nearly a week since their last swap, and now that she's found herself sitting at the breakfast table with Scorpia and Entrapta again, she's starting to think Catra is actually capable of avoiding her forever. The more Adora ponders it, and despite their failed conversation at The Waste, she cant confidently work out why Catra' s so averse to talking. Hasnt she been as secretly excited as Adora is to have a reason to speak again?

Maybe, Adora thinks, *She really doesn't want to see me again.*

It's easy after that to worry about the next thing: *If she won't talk to me and we never figure this out, does that mean we'll keep swapping randomly forever?*

She's shaken out of her doom spiral when Scorpia claps her on the back cheerily, pushing a plate of fried potato pancakes with applesauce in front of her.

"What' s this?"Adora asks, and she immediately regrets it when Scorpia's eyes widen with worry.

"Oh gosh, did I make them wrong? The Google logo said Chanukah started last night and it had a fun little cartoon of these latke things, so I thought it might cheer you up, because, you know, 'T rapta and I have been thinking you've seemed a little bit down the past week or so, and-"

"Actually ,"Entrapta interrupts Scorpia' s ramble, "According to my December log, you've been incredibly inconsistent in character . We found a study about the impacts of enforced festive assimilation on religious minorities, which suggested-"

"Oh! Ahem, not that we've been keeping tabs on you," Scorpia's racing to buffer Entrapta's honesty, "We just wanted to make sure that you don't feel left out because" she gestures at the overload of tinsel, baubles and miscellaneous Christmas decorations that have been hung generously yet haphazardly around their flat, "And we really love you, Wildcat!"

Adora blinks and stares down at the plate in front of her. She's got no idea how Catra feels about Christmas these days, though when they were students, she always came to Adora's house on Christmas Day for lunch. *It's not like there's anything else to do,* she'd always shrugged when Adora's mum invited her over, *I guess I might as well come!*

"This is amazing," she forces a smile onto her face, "Seriously, thank you."

Adora's beyond relieved when Catra's flatmates beam back at her, and it's surprising how much the food reminds her of the treats she used to eat when she visited Catra's childhood home: homemade doughnuts rolled in honey and nuts, blintzes filled with fragrant cheese, and deep bowls of chicken soup with hunks of warming challah bread. She cuts into the plate of latkes and moans with satisfaction when she bites into one, pushing the plate urgently to the middle of the table.

"Oh my God, you have to eat some - Catra would love these!"

She's so steeped in guilt for experiencing this moment in Catra's place that it takes a second for Adora's mind to catch up with her mouth. She peers up shyly to find Scorpia and Entrapta staring back at her, mouths agape.

"I KNEW IT!" Entrapta shouts triumphantly, "This isn't Catra at all!"

"What?" Scorpia chuckles nervously, "Wildcat? How can it not be you?"

"Erm." Adora's practically paralysed as she figures out what to do or say; whether she should laugh it off or risk accusations of insanity.

"There's been something unusual afoot since the first of December," Entrapta supplies before Adora has a chance to respond, "And I've pinned it down to the extreme side effects of trial-stage heart medication - a statistically unlikely hypothesis - or a body swap. And I'm ninety-four percent convinced it has something to do with that Adora ex who Catra's always so cagey about."

"A body swap?" Scorpia guffaws before Adora even has a chance to object to *that* label, "Is that a real thing?"

"Of course!" Entrapta responds, as if Scorpia's question is the most ridiculous she's ever heard, "Haven't you seen Freaky Friday?"

"That's fiction," Adora hears herself say, "Though, you know, the Lindsay Lohan film is a pretty good watch."

Scorpia gasps, her hand flying to her mouth, "You really aren't Wildcat! She would never pick a remake over the original!"

Adora drops her head. It makes her miserable to think that she doesn't know Catra well enough anymore to know if that's true.

"Okay, you're right," she finally admits, "I am Adora. But I can't figure out how to fix it and Catra won't talk to me either."

"Don't worry," Adora instantly brightens when Scorpia takes her hand, her disbelief seemingly overcome in seconds, "We're the Super Pal Trio! Between you and Catra and us, there's nothing we can't work out together!"

Adora grins with gratitude that she's been so swiftly accepted instead of held to account for Catra's version of their history - as an avalanche of questions descend on her, the relief of no longer being in it alone is even sweeter than she imagined.

CHAPTER 5

"Get out of bed. Now ."

Catra glares up at Glimmer from the pillows as she's dragged from slumber. She's in two minds about whether to kick the feisty woman off her - maybe then, she'd finally stop nagging Catra to death every time she's in Adora's body.

"Go away . I'm sleeping."

"Nope. Y ou're hibernating again and it' s weird, and I'm not letting you carry on like this. We're going to the gym."

"I don't want to go to the gym," Catra replies through gritted teeth, "Why won't you just leave me alone?"

Catra doesn't want to hear the answer , to find out how much Adora and Glimmer mean to each other. But she isn't left with a choice - Glimmer softens, collapsing onto her side of the bed and taking Adora's hand.

"I know something' s up, Dor , and you never get stuff off your chest anywhere else. I just wanna talk."

"What if I don't want to talk," Catra says, unsure of whether she' s referring to Glimmer's request or Adora's persistent attempts to make contact, "isn't that allowed?"

"Of course it is!" Sparkles seems horrified by the idea that she might be overstepping, "I just want you to know that I'm here for you, whatever it is. And I.Y. ou know nothing would ever make you less important to Bow and I, right?"

Bow? What's Bow got to do with Adora's relationship?

Catra realises too late that she's allowed her confusion to show too visibly. Glimmer responds hurriedly and it catches Catra by surprise.

"I know you saw us together at The Whispering W oods, Adora, and you've been on and off with us ever since."

Well, yeah, if you're cheating on Adora with fricking Arrow Boy, I'm doing her a favour by being a dick.

Catra's suddenly furious on Adora's behalf.

It's so fucking typical of Sparkles, to get to be with Adora and not appreciate it at all!

"W ell, what do you expect?" Catra retorts angrily , "Didn't you think about her - ahem, me - at all?"

Glimmer pales and she squeezes Catra's hand tighter.

"W e haven't stopped thinking about you, promise! W e've been so anxious to tell you but we really wanted to be sure of our feelings first," Catra follows Glimmer 's eyeline over to the bedroom door and finds Bow standing there anxiously, peering round the frame.

"W e don't want you to feel like a third wheel," Bow speaks gently as he approaches the bed slowly and settles on the edge of the mattress, "W e're still the Best Friend Squad!"

Friend? Catra replays the conversation in her head, *Glimmer and Adora are just friends?*

"W ell, not just friends," Glimmer frowns, raising an eyebrow at her perceived use of the third person, and Catra's shocked to realise she'd spoken aloud, " *Best* friends!"

"No matter what!" Bow pipes up. Catra isn't sure what to make of the conversation - she'd felt kind of wary and bitter about these two ever since Adora first started hanging out with them.

"So, you're shtupping? That's all this is?" Catra's unwilling to admit that her heart feels a little lighter knowing Adora doesn't share this bed with Glimmer romantically, and it isn't only her avoidance efforts that have prevented intimacy when she's been in Adora's body. "Not that I care, but does that mean you're asking for this side of the bed back?"

"Oh!" *Finally,* Catra thinks when Glimmer looks at her totally appalled, *I get to put you on the back foot,* " Adora, that's not what I'm getting at. I know you've not been able to sleep on your own ever since, you know, Catra."

Catra feels herself redden, a deep blush spreading on Adora's skin. She's never thought that Adora felt just as lonely at night as she did. In the old days, they'd always slept in the same bed despite living apart, though half the time it was only for convenience after hanging out late.

"It's been a long time, Dor," Bow interjects cautiously, "If you did want to talk to us more about her, there's no judgement. We know how much you loved her."

Loved?

If Catra was confident of anything, it was that Adora's feelings hadn't been anything close to love when it boiled down to it.

"We just want you to be happy," Bow continues, clearly buoyed by Catra's silence, "We love you, and whether it's repairing things with her or figuring out how to properly move on, we want to help."

Move on?

It's too much. Catra can't stop the tears that start in her eyes and heave from her chest. She hates being stuck in Adora's body, surrounded by her belongings and plunged into a life that she'd been so careful to forget.

“Adora-” Glimmer starts, and it’s enough to push her over the edge.

“I’m not Adora, okay!” she bursts out recklessly. But when Bow and Glimmer exchange glances, she knows they’ve made an entirely different set of assumptions.

“Is there another name that fits better?” Bow asks softly, and Catra feels even more awkward recalling how Adora had told her Bow was starting HRT the summer before their third year of college.

“I dont mean it like that,” Catra cringes, cursing the wild ride the morning has taken her on, “I know this sounds crazy. But I’m Catra.”

Bow looks infinitely confused but Glimmer narrows her eyes curiously, “Oh, God. You were at The Whispering Woods that night, werent you? I knew I saw Adora watching you!”

“Glim?” Bow’s even more confused now, but Catra interrupts him before he can say anything further.

“Wait, you know about this?”

Glimmer groans, “It happened to my mum and Aunt Casta when I was a kid, but I never really believed them before. Did you find Madame Razz?”

“Yeah, but she was like zero fucking help.”

“She only appears to people using her magic,” Catra feels like she’s been caught in a whirlwind with the speed at which Glimmer’s train of thought turns, “Damn, I really thought Adora was growing out of that hair poof.”

“Am I going mad or are you talking about magic?” Bow butts in, “Because as far as I know, The Whispering Woods is just a pub.”

“There’s no such thing as just a pub, babe,” Glimmer says matter of factly, “Especially not at this time of year.”

Her eyes glint when they connect with Bow's, and Catra doesnt want to think about what nasty business they've been getting up to under the mistletoe.

"Okay lovebirds, can we stop the googly eyes and focus on the situation at hand, please? This has been a nice reunion and all but I'd really like to get back to my own life."

Glimmer chuckles and given their fraught history, Catra's surprised she's in a good mood instead of cussing her out.

"Well, I can tell you now that there's only one way that's going to happen and I'm guessing you're not gonna like it."

"What?" Catra's heart sinks, right at the very same time her phone starts to buzz, her own name lighting up the caller ID.

"For starters, you're going to have to answer that."

CHAPTER 2

She's managed to stay inside her own body for five whole days but Adora cant believe that she keeps finding new messages from Catra since their last swap.

First, it was the '*thanks for the food'* note scribbled in biro on Adora's forearm for the vegan meals she'd batch-cooked for Catra in the freezer. Then she'd discovered doodles of Bow and Glimmer in the sketchpad stashed in her bedside table, followed by her completion of Adora's half-done list of gift ideas for the friends that Catra had lost touch with after their fallout. Her favourite, though, was when she got to work and found Catra's annotations added carefully in light pencil all over her portfolio - feedback on the composition of her photos and the details of her editing choices. It

reminded her of the long nights Catra used to spend with her in the dark room when Adora first accepted the job from Angella Moon, Glimmer's mum and one of the field's most celebrated editorial photographers. It had meant so much to Adora that Catra had been supportive at the time - even though fashion magazines and art galleries were miles away from the journalistic photography Adora always dreamed of pursuing, Catra understood that financial stability was what mattered most to her at the time. She'd been the only person who hadn't questioned Adora's choices, simply hugging her tight and buying her a celebratory drink after she signed the contract.

Now she's back in Catra's apartment with Scorpia and Entrapta, she's even more surprised to see her contact ID updated on Catra's phone.

CATRA <3 Nice to see I've been taken off the blacklist ;)

ADORA BOO: Dont push it, Princess. Scorp made me do it.

Her heart leaps a little at the return of her old nickname and Adora wonders what would happen if she actually did push things further.

CATRA <3 I liked your present ideas. Wanna help me shop today?

She almost falls out of bed when she gets a reply mere seconds later.

ADORA BOO: Sure, got nothing else to do.

When they meet at the Bright Moon Christmas markets, Adora's surprised to see Bow and Glimmer with Catra, even though she knows her friends have joined the mission to fix the body swapping. Catra's sheepish when she approaches Adora, rubbing her gloved hands together.

"This is okay, yeah? That I said they could tag along?"

"Of course," Adora smiles brightly , though part of her wishes they could have some privacy, "I didn't think you'd be getting along so well."

"They're not as terrible as I thought," Catra shrugs and walks of f towards the first set of stands before Adora can question her any further.

Glimmer smirks, hugging Adora tightly and prodding her cheek, "If I didn't believe it before, I definitely do now . Never thought I'd see Catra with a smile as wide as that."

"Hey , she smiles!" Adora jests.

"Only at you," Glimmer teases, leaning into Bow when he brings his arm around her shoulders. Adora rolls her eyes and jogs to catch up with Catra. She wishes Glimmer's comment didn't af fect her but her chest's already squeezing with nervous desire.

"I'm glad Glimmer and Bow aren't being weird," she finally decides to say when they're perusing some handmade baubles, "Hopefully they can help you out when we're swapped."

Catra nods a little stiffly but she seems eager to keep the peace, "Y eah, it's been nice, I guess. Scorp and T rapta said it's been good getting to know you too."

Adora exhales in relief;she' s not been entirely confident of how Catra's friends feel about her given the stories she assumes they've been told.

Neither of them speak much as they walk through the stalls, only chatting when they notice items that look like they'd make good presents, or apologising for the graze of one's arm against the other's. They pick out horoscope art prints for Glimmer and wooden figurines for Bow, dried flower teas for Perfuma, artisanal sea salts for Mermista and Sea Hawk, handmade body butters for Scorpia, and tiny spanners carved from chocolate for Entrapta. Adora's

surprised by the skill with which Catra suggests presents for the friends she's hardly spoken to in years, though she supposes they all spent enough time together in the past. When they reach a stall selling bespoke jewellery, Adora asks the question that's been playing on her mind since the start of the month.

"Hey. You never told me how you ended up working at Crimson Jewels. I always assumed you'd got one of those glass apprenticeships in Dryl you'd applied for."

"I got both, actually," Catra concedes, "Like, a couple weeks after we stopped talking. But when it came to it, I didn't want to leave Bright Moon. I wasn't really, um, in the best headspace," she pauses awkwardly like she expects some kind of interruption but continues when Adora stays quiet, "Anyway, I saw an apprenticeship come up at Scorpia's old studio, applied on a whim and it stuck. That's how I met her and Entrapta, though we ended up at Crimson when they bought Scorp out."

"You're really good at it," Adora compliments her, thinking of the intricate metalwork and gem placements she's come to realise are Catra's signature style, "I love your designs."

"Thanks. You're not so bad at making them anymore. I don't have to do so many corrections when we swap back."

Adora nods bashfully and she notices Catra's wearing the same timid smile as she is. Her hand darts out to take Catra's palm in hers before she realises what she's doing, and for a split second, it feels like they're living in another timeline;one where Catra had reciprocated all of Adora's feelings and she got to love her in the way she'd always wanted to.

"Oh, sorry!" Adora exclaims, making to pull away once she's come to herself. But Catra only tightens her hold around Adora's fingers. They walk hand in hand for a few quiet minutes and Adora's heart beats wildly before Catra breaks the silence.

"I'm sorry ," she starts, "For going MIA on you."

"It' s okay."

"It' s not. I just..it was too much. This, you, Glimmer ..."

"Glimmer?"

"And when you wanted to meet at Plumeria... Y ou probably could have said anything at The Waste and I'd have flipped out."

Adora purses her lips, still wishful that she could get Catra to tell her version of events but convinced that forcing it now could only end in disaster.

"How about we just wait until we're both ready to talk about it? No pressure?" Adora finally lands on a response that doesn't feel like she's cheating herself but still moves them forward.

"That sounds good," Catra agrees.

"Good. Then it'll happen when it happens."

CHAPTER 3

It's the seventh morning that Catra's woken up in Adora's body, and for the first time, she almost looks forward to Adora's day.

Now that Glimmer and Bow can tell whether it's Catra or Adora in her body, it's made the early starts so much more bearable - there's no expectations that she'll be as cheerful as Adora, or that she'll have the appetite for any kind of hearty breakfast, let alone one of Adora's gross protein shakes. Not that Catra wants to admit it, but it's been kind of nice talking with them properly after all this time. She'd never really gotten to know them before the fallout; she'd been

too jealous of the time Adora spent with Glimmer and Bow instead of her, and of their shared passion for photography she felt completely locked out of. That's starting to change a little too, given Adora's day job at Angella' s studio alongside Glimmer. Catra's finding she can get lost for hours editing the images she's sent from Angella's senior photographers, though she isn't sure how much Adora must enjoy it.

"Does Adora like this?" Catra asks Glimmer in their morning cof fee break, "Just editing and stuf f? I've seen her personal portfolio," - *well, I've scribbled all over it, but only to be helpful!* - "and it isn't anything like this editorial work."

Glimmer shrugs, hugging her mug closer to her chest as she leans on the cramped kitchen counter, "I think so. Y ou know what she's like, she doesn't complain much. But I could talk to her about it."

"Don't sweat it. She' s probably fine if she hasn't said anything by now."

I want to be the one to talk to her about important things, Catra thinks to herself, *just like old times.*

It takes Catra aback, the strength with which she feels someone has to look out for Adora better and make sure she's still going after her dreams.

There's only so many staged Christmas shoots for glossy magazines that a girl can get through before she starts to lose her marbles, Catra muses, *especially when the girl in question wanted to capture images that could change the world.*

She spends the evening researching photography fellowships and grants that she thinks Adora's portfolio has a chance of winning, and she digs out the old personal statements on Adora's laptop that she remembers helping her write years ago, annotating edits and adding credentials that she knows Adora's gained in her current role. She lays everything out on Adora's dresser when they get back to the

flat, explaining herself on post-it-notes and labelling print-outs of grant submission criteria.

She's worked hard to get her soldering skills up to scratch for my career, Catra tells herself, *I'm only returning the favour.*

Still, it makes her smile when she wakes up next to Melog the following day and finds a brand new text from Adora on her phone.

ADORA BEE : Thanks for doing all of that research for me, Cat. It means a lot.

CATRA GOD No worries. Never liked seeing good talent go to waste.

ADORA BEE : ♡

Catra stares at Adora's emoj for far longer than she wants to admit, failing to stop the swell in her chest that she'd managed to quash for five long years.

CHAPTER 2

The relief of waking up in her own body on Christmas Day feels like the biggest weight off Adora's shoulders in weeks. She rolls over to find Glimmer fast asleep, and for a split second, she imagines it's Catra next to her in bed. She visualises reaching out for the other woman, winding her arms around her torso and pressing good morning kisses to the curve where her shoulder meets her neck. It's a fantasy Adora's kept at bay for long enough, that once permeated her dreams and flooded her idle mind, and that she's got used to chasing away with a sharp dose of reality. Yet when Adora twists again to grab her phone, it seems she's been on Catra's mind as much as Catra's been on hers.

CATRA GOD Merry Christmas, Princess. Hope you have a good one 🎄

It'd be better if you were here, Adora wants to reply, *I can't believe you're up this early* .

ADORA BELL : Happy Sunday, Catra 🥹 thanks!

And then, before she can chicken out…

ADORA BELL : Do you want to come home with me? For old times' sake?

Three dots, disappearing and reappearing on loop.

CATRA GOD Are you sure? It's not too last minute?

It's not if it means I get to spend the day with you, Adora works through the logistics in her mind, *Even if I have to cook before we leave.*

ADORA BELL : Ill pick you up at 1 1.

The drive to Adora's childhood home is more familiar than Catra expected. She remembers almost every turn of the forty minute route, and it's easy to settle into the long-lost habit of watching Adora as she drives, mirroring the blonde's focus on the frosty roads winding out of central Bright Moon to the suburbs. Seeing each other in their own bodies makes everything seem so much more charged to Catra too;every touch and shared expression feels so much more significant now theyŕe seeing each other properly for the first time. When Adora's wrist moves towards the gear stick, her left pinky mere millimetres from the flesh of Catra's thigh, she wonders what

would happen if she rested her palm atop Adora's knuckles or brought their hands to rest together on her lap.

Would she want me, if I told her how much I wanted her all those years ago? Catra asks herself, *Or would it undo all the progress we've made and leave us swapping forever?*

It's too risky to hope for the best. Instead, Catra spends the rest of the drive convincing herself that Adora's newly rosy cheeks and rambling babble can be explained away by the shock of the chilly weather. Yet her attempt to quash her longing doesnt entirely work; as they coast through outer Bright Moon with the radio on, Catra's entranced by how much Adora's voice soothes her when she sings along to festive songs, and when the blonde catches her eye, it's almost like her baby blues are sparkling. It takes everything Catra has not to stare openly at the other woman and to stop herself from tracing the half-dimple in Adora's cheek with her thumb, or from leaning over to neaten up the shirt collar that peeks out of her horrendous Christmas jumper . It's a blessing when they finally arrive at Adora's childhood home and Catra can finally breathe normally again.

"Adora! My baby!" Marlena runs out in her slippers to greet them despite the cold, her rubber soles squeaking on the frosty concrete driveway, "And Catra - this is such a treat!"

Adora giggles when her mother crushes her with a hug, her smile only spreading wider when Marlena does the same to Catra. The warmth of Marlena's reception adds to Catra's list of surprises for the day;after her initial surprise, she hurries to wrap her arms around Adora's mum in return.

"About time!" Adora rolls her eyes as her father Randor roars from the front door, ushering them all inside and taking a bag of Tupperware boxes from Adora, "We've missed you both."

"Did you finally get your head out of your arse?" Catra hears Adora's twin Adam murmur into his sister's ear when they embrace, "Cos this

lil’reunion is loooong overdue.”

“Shut up, dude,”Adora grumbles under her breath but Catra still manages to overhear, her smile faltering a little at Adora’s rebuke, “W e’re friends and we only just started speaking again, alright?”

Adam shrugs - *if you say so* - and holds up his hands in mock surrender before he saunters over to Catra.

“The honorary Grey , back at the Christmas table!”

Quick to hide her disappointment, Catra lets herself get caught in a hug, fixating on the warmth that Adora’s family are showing her rather than fretting that she’s out of place. When they’re all seated at the dinner table, she stops worrying that anyone’s doing her a favour with this lunch invite - if anything, she feels just as comfortable among Adora and her relatives as she always did. For a moment, their eyes connect across the table - and despite the twisting in her gut, Catra feels like she can see right into Adora’s soul, a long lost warmth radiating between them.

“It’ s wonderful to see you girls being friendly again,”Marlena says, and the second Catra tears her eyes away from Adora, she already misses her gaze, “It’ s been so long since we last had you round, Catra.”

Catra struggles to combat her negative thoughts as she thanks Marlena for hosting her.

See? No-one in their right mind would think Adora’s interested in you like that! She never wanted you the way you wanted her.

Despite Catra’s internal dialogue, it’s impossible to look away from the blonde while the Greys chatter around them. Yet as Adora’s parents bring dish after dish to the table, Catra’s stomach drops. She can’t see anything that she’ s definitely sure she can eat, and the last thing she wants is to create a fuss or detract from Randor and Marlena’s generosity.

"Adora, get Catra's plate, won't you?"

Catra straightens in her chair as Adora slips into the kitchen, and it's only Randor's knowing smile that stops Catra from objecting to any extra effort made.

"You didn't think our girl would bring you all the way out here without making sure you could eat, did you? She started cooking right after she called to tell us you were coming."

She did?

"Whipped!" Adam snorts right as Adora returns with a loaded plate of food, and Catra can tell by her whiny hiss that she can't get much more embarrassed.

"Thank you," Catra gushes when her meal is set in front of her and Adora's hand rests on the back of her chair for a moment before she takes her own seat, "You really didn't have to go to all this trouble."

"No trouble at all," Adora smiles at her and it's so genuine and warm, it feels like the past five years never happened, "I'm - *we're* - just so glad you could join us."

CHAPTER 2

Oh no, Adora thinks when she wakes up on the floor of her childhood bedroom and finds Catra dead asleep in the wrong body, *How are we going to fool Mum and Dad?*

She tiptoes to the bathroom, careful not to make the floorboards creak, and shuts herself in there, her hands clamping onto the edge of the sink. The more she stares at Catra's face in the mirror, the more Adora dwells on how right it felt for Catra to come home with

her for Christmas, even if she'd spent the entire day batting away Adam's relentless taunting.

Who am I kidding? Adora cracks when she sees her sadness seep through Catra's mismatched irises, a sob bursting sharply from her throat, *I'm just as in love with her as I always was.*

"Catra, darling?" Marlena's at the bathroom door and Adora hurries to pull herself together, "Is everything alright?"

"Yep," Adora calls out, "I'm all good."

She hears Marlena step closer to the door, "There's no shame in a few tears. Can I come in?"

Adora takes a deep breath before she opens the bathroom door, and she wishes more than anything that she was in her own body and could burrow unreservedly into her mother's embrace.

"What's all this?" Marlena reaches out to her face and sweeps Adora's tears off Catra's cheeks with the pads of her thumbs, "Do you want to talk about it?"

Adora starts to shake her head, but when she sees the concern in her mother's eyes, it all comes tumbling out.

"I missed her so much," she confesses, wary not to say anything that would seem too out of character for Catra, "And all of us being together makes me feel like I should have done something sooner. I've missed her for so long and it's stupid."

"Hey," Marlena smiles softly, "I know Adora missed you too. We all did. But try not to get hung up on what did or didn't happen, hmm? You're here now, aren't you?"

Adora nods, "I just wish I could figure out why she. What happened, you know, back then."

"There' s a little thing called a conversation, my love. Perhaps you both could try it? Between you and me, if there's anything I know about my Dora, it's that she's not always so great at using her words."

Adora laughs through her tears, "Thanks, Mu- Marlena."

"That' s okay, poppet,"she squeezes Adora' s arm, "Y ou get yourself cleaned up for breakfast."

Adora splashes her face once her mum has left, though when she turns to make her way out the bathroom, she finds Catra waiting anxiously in the hallway. Adora's sure she's overheard the entire conversation but Catra doesnt say anything;she slips into the bathroom once Adora's out and locks the door behind her, her eyes downcast as they pass each other. When Catra returns to Adora's bedroom and hovers in the doorway, Adora isnt sure what to do. They've avoided talking about their estrangement for ages and now it feels more taboo than ever.

"Should we talk?"Adora blurts out at the same time that Catra finally speaks, "I made you something."

"Oh?"Adora stammers, "Y -You did?"

Catra nods and closes the door behind her, rummaging in her backpack. She pulls out a small box wrapped in brown paper and gives it to Adora;it' s clear from the tremble in her hand that she's nervous, and Adora can tell it's important to her. She pries the brown paper off the box carefully and opens it to find a delicate charm hanging on a thin chain inside. It's a tiny rendering of a camera in silver with colourful gems placed where the lens and flashlight would be.

"Oh, wow ,"Adora marvels as she holds it closer to her , "This is beautiful. You really made this?"

"Yeah. It's an anklet," Catra says quietly, wringing her wrists, "I hope you like it."

"I love it," Adora gazes at Catra and she wishes for the second time that day that they'd woken in their real bodies so she could see how the silver feels against her own ankle, "Can you wear it for me today? So when we swap back, it'll already be on?"

Catra moves forward tentatively and steps her foot out; Adora shuffles closer and fits the jewellery around her ankle, suppressing the shiver that ripples through her when her fingers skim over the bone. When she returns to full height, they're standing so close that she can see the freckles of grey in her own blue irises and feel the ghost of Catra's breath on her skin.

"I never meant to freak you out when I invited you to Plumeria back then," she whispers, and Catra blinks at the statement, "But you have to know how much it hurt when you never came."

Catra blinks again, and Adora prays that it's okay she's brought it up again before Catra finally replies, her speech heavy with emotion, "What do you mean? I waited for you for hours. And then you never messaged me, or called, and you just, like, disappeared."

"What? I-"

"You left me in the freezing cold, and I really thought. I thought"… Catra looks away as her voice trails off, and suddenly Adora needs to know what's in Catra's mind more than anything.

"What, Cat?"

She sighs bitterly, and Adora knows immediately that Catra's done.

"It doesnt matter ."

Adora wants to tell her, *of course* , it matters, but Catra seems so resigned that she isn't sure there's any purpose to digging further .

Still, she's determined to get to the bottom of what happened when they were younger, even if it's only to get final confirmation that she really had scared Catra away.

"It doesn't make sense, if you were at Plumeria," Adora says, her pulse thumping, "I swear , I really was there"…

"How? I never saw you. Or heard anything from you at all!"

"I don't know ," Adora frowns, "I was embarrassed. I needed some space, but when I did get in touch, none of my messages would go through."

"I blocked you for a while," Catra admits, running a hand through her hair guiltily, "It made me feel like we were even."

Adora sits on the edge of her bed, rubbing her eyes with the heels of her palms. She can sense Catra wrapping her arms around herself, making herself so small and tiny like she hardly wants to exist at all. Adora wishes she had the confidence to reach out and unfurl Catra, and she's suddenly desperate to prove that neither of them are the guilty party;if the whole thing comes down to some stupid cosmic misstep, then maybe they can go back to how they were before.

"It doesn't make any sense. If we were both there, how"…And then, out of nowhere, it comes to her - *I waited for you in the freezing cold* - "Catra, you didn't go to the little outdoor kiosk near campus, did you?"

"Of course I did, that' s the one we always used to." Catra trails of f and she drops into place next to Adora on the mattress, "Don't tell me you were at the big Plumeria branch in town."

"Y eah," Adora doesn't know whether to cry or laugh, "It' s"…

It's way more romantic around there with all the candles and the fancy restaurants and the Christmas lights.

They stare at each other, unbelieving. For a few beats, the only sound is the faint clattering of pots and pans in the kitchen, the rest of Adora's family gearing up for their post-Christmas breakfast.

"You're such an idiot," Catra says eventually, "So am I, I guess."

Adora smiles weakly, her head spinning. *All these years lost, over a silly mistake?* She's already beating herself up before it dawns on her. *If Catra came, and she cared enough to wait that long in that freezing weather, could it mean she felt the same way?*

"God. We really are," Adora goes out on a limb and she takes Catra's hand in hers, "Can we pretend it never happened? Clean slate?"

"Yeah," Catra exhales heavily, squeezing Adora's hand in response, "Let's start again."

CHAPTER 8

"Oh, fuck," Catra says the minute she wakes up, her eyes trained on the ceiling.

"Catra? You're still here?" Glimmer rolls over to face her, pushing her elbow over the stack of pillows between them, "This is the third day in a row-"

"Yes, I know it's the third fucking day! What the hell?"

"Well maybe there's something we just haven't thought of yet, like-"

"Sparkles." Glimmer shuts up abruptly and Catra interrupts her as soon as she opens her mouth again, her whole body deflating atop the mattress, "Unless you can give me a surefire fix, I really don't want to hear it."

Catra feels like she's going crazy. After she and Adora spent Christmas together and finally hashed everything out, she really thought the whole swapping thing would be over. But instead, Catra's totally stuck. She misses Melog, and her best friends, and even her stupid workstation in the front window of Crimson Jewels. Yet more than anything else - even though she really doesn't want to admit it - she misses seeing Adora in her true body and watching all of her *intrinsically Adora* movements and expressions play out exactly how they're supposed to.

"You alright over there?"

Glimmer's question catches Catra out and she realises she's sniffling, her brow knit tight as she stares ahead. She clears her throat roughly, determined not to give anything away.

"You wanna take your mind off it or do you wanna talk about it?"

"Huh?" Catra turns to look at Glimmer, and when she finds her, she's wearing a knowing grin that Catra isn't sure has ever been directed at her before.

"Distraction or deep chat? What'cha having?"

Adora's not sure what Glimmer's cooking up but she sure as hell isn't going to mope around Catra's flat for another day.

"Hoo boy, this is really something," Scorpia's entranced as soon as she follows Adora into the club, her eyes reflecting the shimmer of the mirrorball as she takes everything in, "I didn't even know they did this kind of thing in the daytime!"

Adora laughs uncomfortably, scratching the back of her neck as she rises on her tiptoes to see over the crowd, "Yeah, Glimmer and Bow like these Happy Rave things but I dont often go."

It's a white lie, really - Adora never goes. She hasnt got anything against day parties (if anything, she likes the idea of it a lot more than the messy club nights they went to in their art college days), but they always end in visions of the joy in Catra's face when one of her favourite songs came on, or how neither of them ever said anything when they woke up groggy the next day, Adora's face still buried in the crook of Catra's neck.

"Look, tiny drinks!" Entrapta shouts with glee, clapping her hands together as she runs towards the bar, "I want the green one!"

There's a scuffle around her as Scorpia chases and calls after Entrapta hurriedly. Adora cant imagine what Entrapta would be like drunk, though right as she's about to follow suit, she catches sight of Catra. Her golden hair has been let down to fall freely down her shoulders and back;she's clad in black denim, tight red satin and heavy Doc Martens, and Adora cant remember any time she's dressed her body like this before. For a second, her throat constricts and she cant do anything but stare as she sees Catra's mannerisms play out through her own features: the way she nods and rolls her eyes playfully when Glimmer giggles in her ear, and how she chews on her bottom lip when she pretends that she's still listening. Adora's stealing time, hoarding the seconds until Catra finally notices her and they go back to tiptoeing around one another. It could be seconds, minutes or hours - either way, Adora knows itll never feel like long enough.

She isnt sure how long it actually takes, but she's pulled over to the bar by Glimmer and Bow right after she finally makes eye contact with Catra.

"See, Catra," Glimmer says gleefully , gesturing towards the purple crop top and low-rise grey cargo trousers Adora's borrowed from

Entrapta, "There *are* colours besides red and black that look good on you."

"You look amazing," Adora blurts out before she can respond, earning a raised eyebrow from Catra.

"Hmm," she says, looking Adora up and down, "Not sure whether you're complimenting me or yourself there, to be honest."

Oh, Adora blushes, not confident enough to say that all she really sees is Catra in front of her. *Is it weird if I tell her that?*

There's no need for Adora to decide in the end. The beat drops and Adora counts her blessings when Glimmer thrusts a bottle of beer into her hand and drags her into the middle of the dancefloor. She can feel Catra's eyes boring into her as she sips her beer and jumps around with her friends. Soon, Catra even starts to join in, a wide smile spreading across her face when Scorpia and Entrapta find them. The club heaves with energy, 90s pop and R&B pushing through their bodies while they dance, and Adora doesn't think she's felt this weightless in weeks. Moving Catra's smaller body is so much easier than choreographing her own heavy limbs, and when Adora flings her arms in the air, her lips shaping around lyrics she hasn't sung in a decade, she almost feels liberated, finally freed from the stress and tension of the body swaps. It feels good, better than Adora's felt in a long time. But then…

No matter how hard I try, you keep pushing me aside. And I can't break through. There's no talking to you…

Adora feels her skin prickling all over as familiar bars of music begin to pulse through the air. She turns around slowly and catches Catra in the middle of the crowd, her chest rising and falling steeply as her breath quickens.

Adora glances up at Catra through her eyelashes and before she knows it, the other girl steps closer. Adora's breath catches in her throat and even though she swallows it quickly, she can tell Catra's

noticed it when her pupils bob up and down from Adora's lips to her gullet and back. She grabs Catra's hand on impulse and pulls them together with a little too much force;Catra stumbles and falls into Adora's orbit, her wrists knocking onto Adora's shoulders.

"S-sorry , Adora,"she stammers before Adora can shake her head, brown ringlets skimming Catra's hands.

"No, no. Iʼm sorry , it's my fault. I didnt mean-"

"What?"Catra yells, "I cant hear you!"

It's so sad that you're leaving. It takes time to believe it. But after all is said and done, you're gonna be the lonely one, oh.

"I said it' s my fault, I shouldnt have-"

"I know ,"Catra says, smirking, "it' s just not so often that Adora Grey says sorry. I wanted to hear it again."

Adora blinks, running through their conversations over the past month. She doesnt remember apologising for her part in their fall out at all, even if it isnt strictly anyone' s fault.

"Iʼm sorry ."

"Y ou dont have to say it again, Adora, it' s just a joke."

"But I am,"Adora presses on, "Iʼm sorry , for not trying harder. Or reaching out. Or telling you that I l-"

Oh no, Adora stops talking immediately and reins herself in before she does something stupid. Like telling Catra how she really feels about her, how she's always felt.

Do you believe in life after love? I can feel something inside me say, I really don't think you're strong enough, no!

"T elling me what?"

It’s no use - Catra’s always been too quick for Adora, far too fast to hide from.

“I—” Adora hesitates, the truth hovering on her tongue, “I—I’m just so happy we’re friends again.”

“Friends?” Catra’s still smiling but it doesn’t reach her eyes anymore. Adora can’t help but feel she’s said something wrong, like she’s failed to live up to Catra’s expectations. She tries harder. “Yeah, I really missed you. A lot.”

Catra inhales slowly through her nose and she stares right into Adora’s irises like she’s searching for something. When she finally speaks, Adora’s on edge, knowing that whatever Catra was hoping to find likely wasn’t there, “Yeah. Me too.”

There’s nothing wrong with anything either of them say, yet it doesn’t feel *right.* Adora already feels her unspoken love confession souring in the air as Catra dips her head and breaks eye contact. There’s no time to figure out next steps - Catra squeezes her hand before she lets go and then Adora’s alone in the middle of the dance floor, watching her person walk away.

CHAPTER 6

It takes Adora another two days of living in Catra’s body to stop overthinking her friend’s monosyllabic text responses and make her way home. She bundles Melog into their carrier and tries to stop her knee from jittering as they ride through the snowfall in Scorpia’s beat up car, cursing the unholy creak of its rusty windscreen wipers when they shudder over patches of dry frost on the glass. Catra’s surprised when she lets Adora into her own apartment, apologising for Glimmer and Bow’s absence.

f know ,"Adora tells her , f asked them to make themselves scarce."

"Y ou didnt want to hang out with them?"Catra' s voice lilts with disbelief, her head tilting to one side.

"Y ou know they'd take over completely ,"Adora lifts Melog' s carrier gingerly as she moves down the hallway, and she swears there's an excitable spark in Catra's irises before she sets the cat carrier on the living room carpet, "Y ou'd get no quality time with Melog at all."

Catra nods and bites her lip as she makes her way to the cat carrier - Adora wonders if these ambiguous head movements are the only form of communication she's going to get out of Catra these days. Adora gets her answer in mere seconds;Catra' s excitement buzzes in the air when Melog rushes to her lap, her unrestrained laughter ringing out loudly as they nuzzle their cheek to her palm. It's the perfect opportunity to break the tension between them. Adora kneels next to Catra, grinning as she watches the two of them reunite after so many days apart. Once Melog's curled up to sleep on Catra's lap, it isnt long until Adora ends up joining them, huddling on the sofa like old times.

"s it okay if I put the TV on?"Catra reaches across Adora awkwardly to grab the remote and Adora's thigh burns where Catra's stomach briefly makes contact, "f know you dont really like watching stuf f these days."

"f like watching stuf f,"Adora' s quick to reassure, and her heart swells a little when it earns her a soft smile.

"f you say so, Princess. 'Cos I heard you dont do this anymore."

Adora shrugs and waits for Catra to put something on. She doesnt really register what Catra decides to play, agreeing to every suggestion. She's too tuned into how the other girl hums under her breath while she's browsing Netflix. Catra settles on some shitty Christmas rom-com in the end;anyone else would say it' s uncharacteristic, though Adora knows better. She's always seen the

softest, gooiest parts of Catra that no-one else has access to. When it gets to the end of the film and their hands accidentally meet over Melog's soft fur, Adora doesnt let go of Catra' s fingers. She keeps holding on and Catra's eyes skim over their hands, then Adora's eyes and her lips, and when she leans in by a millimetre - it's imperceptible, really - Adora wonders if she's just imagining things.

"Thanks for the movie," she says, speaking so quietly that it' s a miracle Catra hears her at all, "I missed this."

"Y ou told me that already," Catra points out, and Adora cringes at the fresh memory of their not-wrong conversation gone wrong, "But you could tell me again."

Adora's heart drums harder and her blood seems to rush so fast inside her veins that it almost hurts. She stares at Catra, willing herself to open up properly, once and for all.

"I miss holding you," she says with trepidation, unsure whether it' s a good thing if Catra understands what she's really trying to say (what's she's always meant to say), "And falling asleep with you. Watching TV s lonely without you."

Catra opens her mouth and closes it again, before she shakes her thoughts away. Adora wants so badly to know what's going through her mind. But Catra doesnt move closer and she doesnt say anything back, and Adora's desperation to dig herself out of a dangerous hole swallows her up and pushes her to her feet.

"I really missed you," she repeats her words from the club while the knot in her stomach sinks sorely, "But I should probably go. Stuf f to do."

"I'm happy we're friends again, Adora," Catra' s voice is gentle even though she's looking away now, like she doesnt want to have to watch Adora leave, "I'm glad that we can be."

Adora smiles, though she doesnt feel happy in the way she thinks she should.

"Me too, Cat," she says before she starts packing up, keen not to let her disappointment show, "I'm glad as well."

CHAPTER 3

If it wasnt for Melog, Catra isnt sure she'd have the mettle to get through the day. Glimmer and Bow have been running around for hours in the flat, screaming that they need mixers, or nibbles or a better playlist, or some other shit Catra cant believe they didnt think of yet.

"God, did you two prepare anything for this party?" Catra scoops a steep cliff of guacamole onto a tortilla chip, "Adora really does keep this ship sailing, huh?"

"Get out of my guac!" Glimmer shouts, "That' s for the guests!"

Catra snorts as Melog wraps their tail around her ankle and rubs on her shin, though Bow ruins the moment when he pouts at them.

"Did you even remember to invite anyone?" Catra goes for a second chip, enjoying the invisible explosion she can see taking place in Glimmer's brain.

"This is what I get for making sure there' s vegan shit," Glimmer steals the bowl of guacamole off the coffee table and runs into the kitchen to seal it with cling film, throwing Bow her sharpest glare when he follows her, "I told you this was a bad idea!"

"Perfuma' s vegan too, Glim. Anyway , it's nice to make sure everyone can eat."

"Perfuma wont eat the fucking avocado!" Catra attempts to stifle her cackle as she listens in on Adora's flatmates from the living room, collapsing onto the sofa right as Glimmer raises her voice, "She's all pissed off about deforestation in Mexico!"

"Oh my God, stop laughing at us and get of f your ass," Glimmer 's back in the living room now, her hands placed on her hips as she eyes Catra, "Y oure gonna have to pretend you care about this party , you know."

"Ugh, why?"

"Adora would care," Bow' s back as well now, circling his hands around Glimmer's waist, and Catra has to fight to block out a vision of Adora's strong arms wrapping around her own torso, "And everyone's going to think youre her , so"…

Catra rolls her eyes. It's bad enough that Adora's been texting her non-stop with odd-jobs for the party that she knows Glimmer and Bow will have forgotten about, but she didnt think anyone would actually expect her to get involved.

"I've got my own party to plan for . Youre not the only one who celebrates New Year's Eve."

"Are you helping your flatmates right now?" Glimmer retorts.

"No." Melog jumps into Catra' s lap at precisely the right moment for her to make her case, "But Im indisposed."

"Y ou are literally the worst," Glimmer moans, turning to bury her face in Bow's chest in mock dismay.

"I saw you checking me out in Entrapta' s gear the other night," Catra teases. *If I'm stuck here,* she figures, *I'm gonna have as much fun as I possibly can,* "Im pretty sure you like me."

"That was Adora!" Glimmer hisses, and even Bow's struggling to keep a straight face now.

"W as it? Because I'm not getting that pale and blonde is your type."

It's worth it when Glimmer storms out the living room in pretend outrage, slapping Bow's bicep playfully when he cant stop himself from bursting into laughter.

Adora's been waiting all day for Catra to respond to her text, and when her phone finally buzzes it's momentarily the biggest relief.

ADORA BELL : Chill, Princess. Everything's fine

CATRA GOD Did you remember the bean dip?

ADORA BELL : We remembered the guac 🥑

CATRA GOD Perfuma wont eat that 😱I knew I should have brought some over yday

ADORA BELL : Damn, when she starves to death, itll be all your fault

She's halfway through typing a reply when there's a bang in the kitchen, and Adora scurries to find Scorpia slamming a ginormous bag of ice on the table.

"I thought you were only having a couple more people over?" Adora asks as Scorpia shakes off the frost from her fingertips.

"Y eah."

"This is, like, enough ice for a gala."

"Hehe, that's fancy," Scorpia chuckles, hardly looking up at Adora as she shovels ice cubes into a bucket with an old, bent spatula, "They sure do treat ya nice in the photography world, huh?"

"It's for the Prosecco!" Entrapta appears out of nowhere - *do I just not notice when she's here,* Adora wonders - and drops a mountain of mini bottles on top the ice with seemingly little regard for their fragility, "Catra always says that if we're gonna have tiny bottles then we gotta make sure they don't warm up faster!"

"That's smart," Adora concedes, "Maybe she's stocking up on ice at mine."

"Why don't you go?" Scorpia asks, her eyes flitting to the clock on the wall, "It's already eight so people will start arriving soon. You can't miss your own New Year's Eve party!"

"I have to, everyone thinks I'm Catra."

"She wouldn't care," Entrapta supplies, "Actually, eighty-four percent of the time, she actively does what other people don't want her to do."

Adora shrugs, unwilling to admit that part of her is too scared to go to the party at her own flat - she'd only spend the night watching Catra across the room, wishing she'd be her midnight kiss. She busies herself instead, zig-zagging between her instinctive mask of enthusiasm and the toned-down exterior she knows Catra would present. She finds herself checking her phone constantly, waiting for a reason to abandon everything and go to Catra, even though she knows it couldn't be romantic. It's exhausting, and by eleven o'clock, all she wants is to collapse into her own bed across town.

"You seem unhappy," Entrapta says to Adora in front of everyone while they're watching the pre-countdown concert on TV, "Maybe you should go."

"Jesus, T rap," Lonnie, an old friend of Catra' s from school who Adora only ever met twice, takes an amused swig of beer, "Dont pull any punches."

"It' s okay," Adora steps in quickly , uncertain of how self-conscious Entrapta might be, though her concern turns out to be misplaced.

"She has another party to go to," Entrapta says matter of factly , "All her friends are there."

"W ow, way to make a girl feel good," Lonnie raises an eyebrow .

"It' s not like that-"

"Y es it is," Entrapta replies brightly , "Of f you go!"

Adora looks around the room anxiously. She's well and truly fucked this up for Catra, and she's pretty certain that leaving is the last thing shell get away with now . She shimmies further into her seat, picking up her drink as if to make a point, but then…

No matter how hard I try, you keep pushing me aside. And I can't break through. There's no talking to you…

Adora's head snaps to the television screen. She swears it's Mara on stage in the studio, crooning to a slowed down ballad version of Catra's favourite song.

"Fuck, this is kind of depressing without a dance beat," Lonnie comments, "They picked *this* for New Year's?"

It's so sad that you're leaving. It takes time to believe it. But after all is said and done, you're gonna be the lonely one, oh.

Adora hardly registers it when she rises to her feet and moves towards the television.

This can't be happening, she mutters to herself, *It has to mean something.*

And then, it's almost like Mara's talking to her through the screen, her eyes drilling right into Adora's as she crouches in front of the TV.

Do you believe in life after love? I can feel something inside me say, I really don't think you're strong enough, no!

Adora's almost enraged. It's hitting her suddenly - she's never been strong enough to tell Catra how she really feels and it has to end. It's nearly the end of a whole ‘nother year and she can't imagine letting any more time pass by without fessing up, for better or worse.

"Erm, Ador- umm, Catra?"Scorpia pipes up, "Everything okay?"

"I-I have to go,"Adora stammers, rushing to the doorway , "I have to find her."

She doesn't wait for anyone to respond, jamming her feet into Catra's canvas Chucks and running into the sleet outside. The door slams behind her as she digs for Scorpia's spare car keys in her pocket, her breath pushing white clouds in front of the steering wheel when she gets into the driver's seat. Like magic, the radio starts up as Adora rolls out of Catra's street, and Mara's voice rings out loud and clear.

What am I supposed to do? Sit around and wait for you? Well, I can't do that. And there's no turning back.

The ten minute drive to her own apartment feels like it lasts forever; it's eleven forty by the time Adora shoves her way past friends and guests into the living room, grateful that the door's been left on latch so people can come and go. She searches the room in a panic, scouring every corner and surface, moving to the kitchen and bathroom and bedroom, and she can't find Catra anywhere until-

"Hey , what are you doing here?"It' s Bow, his eyes wide with concern, "Aren't you at Catra' s?"

"I need to find her ," Adora' s practically vibrating with urgency, "Where is she?"

"Y ou didn't see her? She left a while ago, I assumed she went home."

"No." Adora looks around her bedroom desperately , as if Bow's made a terrible mistake and she'll find Catra hiding under the bedding, a shit-eating grin on her face, "She didn't. I have to go."

I need time to move on. I need a love to feel strong.

She hardly hears Bow calling after her when she races out the apartment, clambering down the block stairs and half-jumping over the bannister.

It's a long shot, but maybe I can figure out where she is.

Adora fumbles for the car keys when she gets outside, but the snow is falling harder and faster, and when she squints she sees Mermista and Sea Hawk blocking the road right ahead of her, she feels like she could combust.

"What. Y ou guys, I need to get out of here!"

Mermista turns away from the SUV that' s boxing Adora's ride into its space and groans, her gloved hand covering her face, "He set of f a fucking firework and it's, like, smashed the windscreen. We can't drive it, there's glass everywhere."

"My darling, I only did it in honour of your beauty on this hallowed New Year's Eve!" Sea Hawk' s ministrations do little to soothe anyone, "Forgive me-"

"Shut up, dude. W e're like four hours late already , and now-"

Adora can't bear to listen to them bicker any longer . She grabs Catra's phone from her pocket and checks every taxi app but there's

no-one available anywhere this close to midnight, and there's not a moving car or bus on the road in sight.

'Cause I've had time to think it through. And maybe I'm too good for you, oh.

Fuck it, Adora grits her teeth, *I'm going to have to run.*

Adora's breath wheezes with every inhale as the frost cuts into her lungs. She's shivering, her black denim and red plaid button up doing little to keep her warm or dry. But the thought of Catra waiting in the cold pushes her to keep going - the burn in her calves and thighs far outweighs the sting of inhaling icy air as she sprints through the streets of Central Bright Moon, pushing her way past drunken groups and street performers.

Please, please, please let her be where I think she is.

Catra huddles on the street corner by Plumeria Coffee watching her breath turn opaque in the air when it furls past her lips. It's cold, seriously cold, but she couldnt spend another minute in Adora' s flat. There were too many people and too much noise and far too many hugs - but more than anything, there was too little of Adora.

I wish you came, she thinks, *maybe I'd have finally had the nerve to kiss you.*

It's hopeless, and Catra knows it. She's spent long enough trying to interpret Adora's behaviour now, and there's nothing clear cut enough to prove the other woman returns her feelings at all. She sighs, leaning back against the lamppost. It's fitting enough, waiting outside in the cold as she comes to terms with her unrequited love. Full circle, even.

Maybe it's time to admit it. I really just need to move on.

For a second, Catra almost feels powerful. She could choose to let go of this misplaced hope instead of waiting for the impossible to happen. And maybe shell be swapping with Adora forever - but perhaps having Adora in this terrible, twisted, inconvenient way is better than not having Adora at all.

There's music in the distance, bleeding out of the doorway of a bar - the irony of hearing this song in this moment makes Catra laugh to herself.

Do you believe in life after love? I can feel something inside me say, I really don't think you're strong enough, no

She sings the song quietly to herself, glancing at the partygoers spilling out of the bar for a cigarette before the final countdown. There's only five minutes left before midnight strikes, and Catra tells herself that it's the last five minutes she's ever going to give her heart to Adora Grey.

New year, new me. Isn't that what everyone says?

"Ca.Catra!"There' s a voice interrupting her thoughts, breathless and reedy, "C-C-Cat!"

Catra whips her head around. It's Adora, red-faced with chattering teeth. She's dumbstruck for a second, unable to say or move or do anything, but then Adora grabs her hand and the shock of her ice-cold skin jolts Catra out of her paralysis.

"What are you doing here, Adora? Y oure meant to be the party ."

I lied,"Adora squeezes Catra' s hand so hard it starts to hurt.

"What?"Catra has no clue what' s going on, "What are you talking about?"

Adora steps closer, her chest heaving steeply as she pants through her speech, "I know what I said before, but I'm not happy we're friends."

Adora watches Catra's expression turn from confusion to abject hurt, her blue irises disappearing behind closed eyelids.

Fuck. This isn't coming out right.

Catra tears her hand away, but Adora grabs it right back, "Please, listen to me."

"Why would I want to listen to you, Adora?" Catra's furious now, her nose twitching, "All of this swapping, for what? So you can tell me how glad you are we didn't speak for years? What a shit friend I am?"

She laughs with mirth, cutting ripples in the air that feel like they could shred Adora's skin.

"No, no." Adora gulps, but it's only getting worse and if she has any chance of making Catra understand, she has to be as crystal clear as she can, "I just. Dammit, I don't even know how to say this."

Catra stares back at Adora incredulously. It feels like the universe is just trying to fuck with her , one wretched trick after another. Of course, Adora would do this, so desperate to put her out of her misery that she tracks Catra down in the cold.

"You know what?" Catra says carefully, "I don't want to be your friend either. So there. Happy?"

Adora's face twists and even though she's the one that's started this whole stupid conversation, the pain on her features is unbearable. It's like something's snapping in Catra's chest and it's impossible to hold back any longer. If this is goodbye, she's going to go out with a bang.

"Catra, please, this isn't what I meant-"

"I never wanted to be your fucking friend, Adora! Don't you get it? Friends was never... It was never enough," Catra jerks her arm out of Adora's hold, unable to look at her anymore, "But you... you never wanted me the way I wanted you, and I'm done with it. So just leave me alone."

She starts to turn away, ready to go home and figure out how the fuck she's meant to resolve this body swapping if she never talks to Adora again. But her song - *our song?* - is still playing, and Catra feels like she could crumple, and it's impossible to storm off with the decisiveness she wants when her heart feels so unfairly empty it hurts.

"You want me?"

Catra sniffs. Of course Adora is this slow to catch on, and she's going to have to humiliate herself by spelling it out.

"I love you, Adora. I always loved you."

For a second, Adora says nothing and Catra almost feels relieved. It's over, and she's free, and the only thing left to do is lick her wounds. But then she hears a sharp intake of breath, and Adora takes her hand back and pulls her close and Catra's dizzy from how she can feel her skin burning at Adora's touch.

"I never thought I'd hear you say that," Adora's voice is filled with emotion and Catra isn't sure what to do with it, "I love you, too."

"Don't p-play tricks on me," Catra stutters, "I- I can't take it."

"No tricks," Adora leans in, hovering far too close, like she's waiting for permission to kiss her, "I've loved you forever."

Their lips crash as Adora closes the final inches between them and it feels like Catra's never been alive before. Adora's hot and cold at the same time, her arms locking around Catra like she's the only anchor keeping her from being lost at sea, and for the first time, Catra finally believes it.

There's cheering everywhere, and the Bright Moon city bells are ringing midnight, and Adora can hardly bear to let go of Catra when they break apart, her eyes still seized shut.

"I love you too," she whispers again for good measure, "I can't remember a time that I didn't."

Catra's response isn't quite what she expects; she gasps before laughing hysterically, and Adora's about to reply with indignation when she opens her eyes and sees two mismatched irises right in front of her.

"It's you," Catra kisses her again, a brief press to her lips that's all too short, "You're you again."

"You're *you*!" Adora echoes, joining in on Catra's laughter, "It's a good thing I like kissing you a lot more than I like being you."

"That's lucky," Catra says, shimmying her way inside Adora's coat to keep warm, and Adora's immediately appalled that she went outside so poorly clothed, "Though I could always change my mind."

"You won't," Adora says, leaning down to meet Catra's smile with her own, "I've spent enough time in your shoes to know."

End Notes

Thanks so much for reading this fic!I'd love to hear your thoughts, and plan on updating my current WIPs in the next few weeks if you'd like to read more of my fics :)

Deaf Catra / Messy Exes AU: Where it started...

Amnesia AU: pancakes for dinner

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